

Leading ROLES

How Dilip Kumar and Bachchan changed Bollywood's concept of the hero

| By Kaveree Bamzai |



**HERO
VOLUME 1: THE
SILENT ERA TO
DILIP KUMAR**

Price: Rs 595

Pages: 406

**VOLUME 2:
AMITABH
BACHCHAN TO
THE KHANS
& BEYOND**

Price: Rs 595

Pages: 417

by ASHOK RAJ
Hay House India

Can the sum of the parts be less than the whole? If it is Bollywood it can be. In *Hero, Volume 1* and 2,

Ashok Raj has set out on an ambitious journey, one that takes him from Dhundiraj Govind Phalke's small house in Mumbai to actors such as Kamal Haasan, Naseeruddin Shah, Om Puri, Nana Patekar, Manoj Bajpai, Kay Kay Menon, Arshad Warsi, Rahul Bose and Irrfan Khan, whom he unfortunately lumps together in an uneasy cohabitation and labels The Misfits. Along the way, he takes little amusing diversions, telling us of Dilip Kumar's awe at seeing Devika Rani watering the plants in the Bombay Talkies garden, or gives us

fascinating trivia, such as how Kumar has died in the climax of 14 films and how 81 out of a total of 125 Amitabh Bachchan films have been socials. It is also, as its arm-bending weight promises, a lengthy dissection on practically every male actor who has ever had a leading role in Hindi cinema, including Mukesh Khanna and Jaaved Jaffrey.

But it is essentially a thesis on Kumar and his overwhelming influence on actors in Hindi cinema, from Bachchan to Shah Rukh Khan. How I Dote On Dilip Kumar may well have been the book's alternative title and in that Raj, a New Delhi-based research coordinator, doesn't disappoint, analysing each phase in Kumar's commendable career and finding its echoes in the work of later actors, whether it is the faux death of the hero in *Arzoo*, which

Guru Dutt borrowed for *Pyaasa*, or the influence of Jayaprakash Narayan's drive against dacoity in moulding the hero of *Ganga Jamuna*. There are valuable explanations on why and how the 1960s changed Indian cinema in its tone and tenor or the decline of the '80s, the result, says the author, of the collective psychotherapy of Bachchanalia becoming unsustainable.

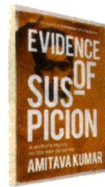
But the book is at its best when breaking down two great lives on screen, Kumar, from romantic tragedian to cosmopolitan leader, and Bachchan, who began as a passionate sufferer and ended up as the backward-looking patriarch. It picks up certain films in their oeuvre and embellishes them with clippings from reviews and interviews of that era, valuable for anyone who is trying to understand the compelling hold of Bollywood on our imagination. In telling us what role, say, a Bimal Roy played in allowing Kumar to learn the importance of "not to do" or how valuable Mukul Anand was in designing Bachchan's comeback vehicles in the early '90s, it reminds us that cinema is a collaborative medium, an aspect that often gets ignored in the valorisation of its stars.

Some of the other chapters seem artificially constructed and hurriedly written to make a muchness of the book. Anil Kapoor, Sanjay Dutt, Sunny Deol and Jackie Shroff, four actors get called the Durable Heroes, while Vivek Oberoi is mentioned in the same league as Hrithik Roshan. Fardeen Khan gets almost equal treatment as Salman Khan in a chapter on New Age Heroes,

which is certainly a disservice to the latter whose tremendous hold on working class audiences requires a book of its own. Read it for a dispassionate account of both Kumar and Bachchan, unusual in the age of hagiography. And understand why these men remain the ultimate heroes in contemporary Bollywood. ■



KUMAR AND BACHCHAN
IN A STILL FROM SHAKTI



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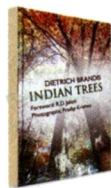
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